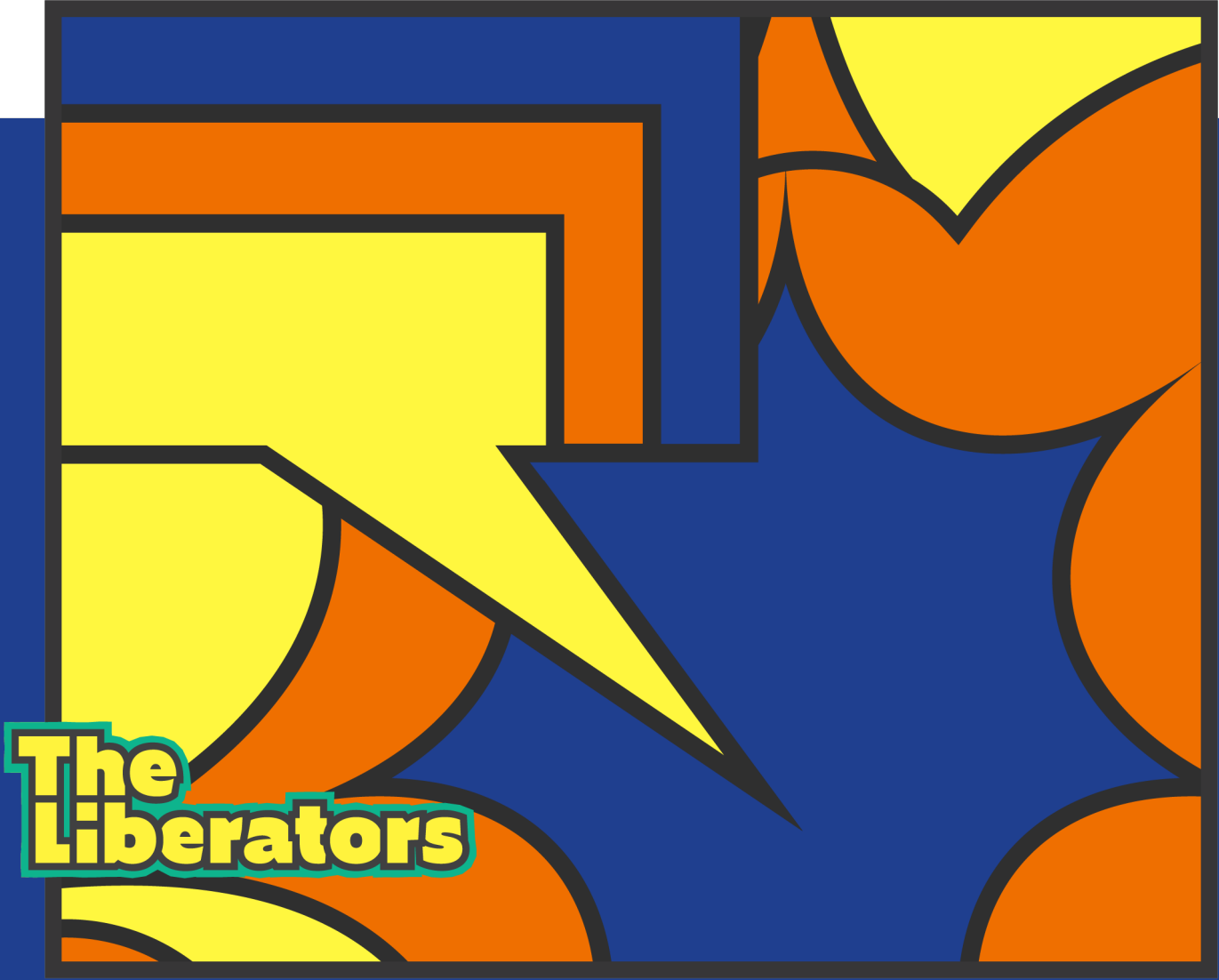


Solve Persistent Impediments Together With Other Scrum Teams

A do-it-yourself workshop to solve the problems that prevent Scrum teams to work empirically and achieving the Sprint Goals



**The
Liberators**

The Purpose Of This Workshop

Hey there,

If a team or organization decides to work empirically with Scrum, they will inevitably run into impediments. An "Impediment" is any problem that blocks the developers of a Scrum team from achieving the Sprint Goal and is outside their control or ability to resolve on their own.

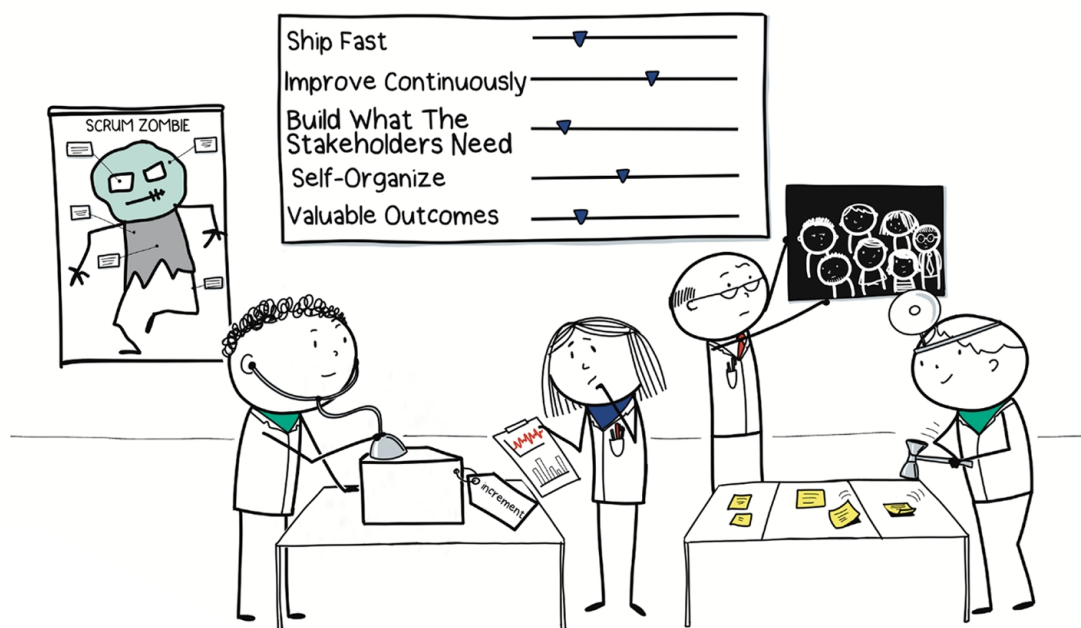
Which problems are "impediments" is something that changes over time. Although the order isn't always the same, most teams start with impediments related to how people understand Scrum (and empiricism) and how to work as a team rather than a bunch of individuals. Only when the majority of issues are solved there, technology issues become more prevalent. Once these are solved, organizational impediments within the value chain are popping up. If the value chain is optimized for Scrum, process issues outside the value chain are encountered, e.g. budgeting, career paths, and strategy processes.

Many impediments often involve other Scrum teams, departments, and people across the entire organization – and those are often outside your immediate control. To overcome those, you need to include other teams and stakeholders as well. That's the purpose of this do-it-yourself workshop: to find solutions for persistent, tough, and challenging impediments, together!

Give this string a try, and let us know the results.

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Created by Theo Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

Flow



Step 1: Opening

 3 min

Step 2: Select The Most Impactful Impediment With 1-2-4-ALL

  25 min

Step 3: Tap The Wisdom Of The Whole Group To Find Potential Solutions

  45 min

Step 4: Define Personal Next Steps

  15 min

Step 5: Closing

 2 min

Total duration

 90 min

Difficulty / Effort



Required Skill



Bringing multiple Scrum teams and stakeholders together, might be challenging. Once that's done, trust the wisdom of the group to find solutions.

Impact On Survival



With this workshop you make the most important problems transparent, and by joint inspection you find local solutions. Repeat this workshop frequently, and you'll be on track to fix Zombie Scrum.



How To Prepare



Group Size

This string of Liberating Structures is feasible from 8 participants and onward. You can also run parallel sessions of this string at the same time, involving many more Scrum teams and many more stakeholders.

Intended Audience

This workshop is designed for multiple Scrum teams and their stakeholders. Invite the stakeholders that are impacted by the problems you address, and that can be part of a solution, or have a real stake in the product and would benefit from solving the problem. This could mean you invite your customers, IT architects, sales department, or line-managers. Do emphasize that their role is to help resolve the impediments a Scrum team faces. Not to bring their own impediments. That's something for a different workshop.

If you're unclear who your stakeholders are, you can create a [Stakeholder Map](#) first. Invite people in the "Promoters"-quadrant first, followed by the "Defenders"-quadrant and a few from the "Latent"-quadrant. If you have space, you can include participants from the "Audience"-quadrant.

Virtual Delivery

Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

Preparation

- Create a shared space (on a wall, the floor, or virtually) where you can collect insights from the various rounds.
- Prepare slides or supporting materials for the various rounds and their invitations.

Resources

- Blog post: [Navigating Conflict, a Lifetime of Work](#)
- Blog post: [Conflict Styles: What Sciences Says](#)
- White paper [The 8 Stances of a Scrum Master](#) with the stance of an Impediment Remover in specific
- Whitepaper: [Scrum: A Framework to Reduce Risk And Deliver Value Sooner](#)
- Myth: [The Scrum Master Must Resolve Every Problem](#)



What Makes An Impediment?

Impediments are those problems that hinder the progress of the Developers in your Scrum team towards the Sprint Goal, and that lie outside of their capability to resolve on their own. This ties impediments strongly to another concept that is central to Scrum: self-management. The more autonomy teams have to work in the way that works best for them, in the order that suits them, and with the tools they need, the fewer problems will turn into impediments. But most teams don't start from a place of great autonomy and are constrained by rules, procedures, and existing tools. These constraints are likely to become, or result in, impediments. For example:

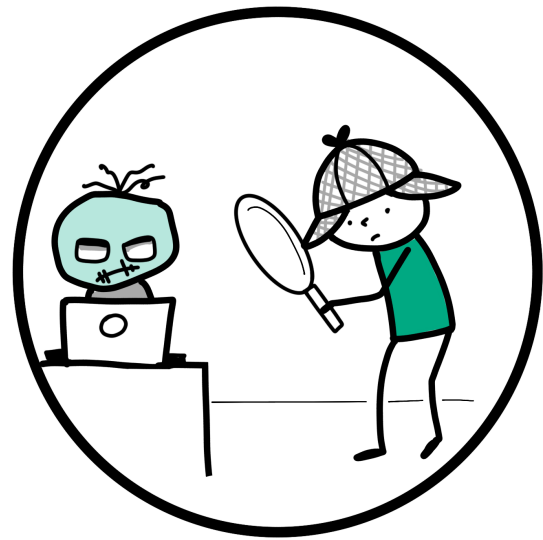
- Team members becoming sick (but who can replace their skills?)
- Problems with the development environment (and nobody can fix it)
- Unavailability of the Product Owner (and all sorts of questions remain unanswered)
- Conflict between team members (and HR should resolve this)
- Bugs in the production environment (but we can't fix them, because another team does that)
- Testing is done by another team (so we are not responsible for quality)

"Impediments are those problems that hinder the progress of the Developers in your Scrum Team towards the Sprint Goal, and lie outside of their capability to resolve on their own."

A great demand is placed on Developers to use their professional expertise, creativity, and collective intelligence to solve problems as they emerge. Within Scrum, the self-managing nature of the team can be understood by their ability to solve the problems they run into, without having to delegate ownership of the problem to people outside the team. In that regard, we prefer to explain impediments as those problems that, when resolved, improve the chances that the developers can solve similar problems on their own the next time they occur.

Many categories of problems are resolvable by Developers, like clarifying unclear specifications, fixing problems in deployment, or even the resolution of a conflict within the team.

The difference may seem trivial, but the consequences are not. Are the Developers truly self-organizing when all problems that arise need a Scrum Master to resolve them? What happens when only the Scrum Master can resolve a conflict between members of the team? What happens when only the Scrum Master can help the Developers clarify unclear specifications with the Product Owner, or break down large chunks of work? What happens when only the Scrum Master can get infrastructural problems resolved? A Scrum Master that solves most of the problems that arise is not doing the Developers any favors. He or she is actively impeding the (growing) ability of the Developers to solve their own problems.



Real-life Examples Of Impediments

In our experience, the term 'impediments' is often quite abstract. Although the definition we shared earlier might offer clarity, it is probably helpful to give some concrete examples. The image below illustrates the Impediment Pyramid created by Dominik Maximini. We will explain the model by giving one example for each "tier":

Example #1: Understanding Of Scrum

Suppose the Developers find themselves in the position where half the team has nothing to do. This is raised as an impediment during the Daily Scrum, and the Scrum Master is asked to find them work. According to the Developer's understanding of Scrum, this is what a Scrum Master should do. The actual impediment here is that the Developers are apparently not collaborating in a manner so that everyone can contribute to achieving the Sprint Goal. Or the accountabilities of the Scrum Master are unclear to the Developers.

Instead of finding work, the Scrum Master does well to investigate why this is happening. He or she might address this during a themed Sprint Retrospective. Or perhaps the Developers are unaware of practices that promote collaboration, like pair- or crowd-programming, breaking up large chunks of work, or testing work by others ('two pair of eyes'). Or maybe there are people in the team that act as 'Towers of Knowledge', and take up the bulk of the work while the rest works on the crumbs.

Either way, the Scrum Master can help the Developers become more self-organizing by finding solutions for these impediments, not for the (symptomatic) problem that is raised during the Daily Scrum.

Example #2: Scrum Team Formation

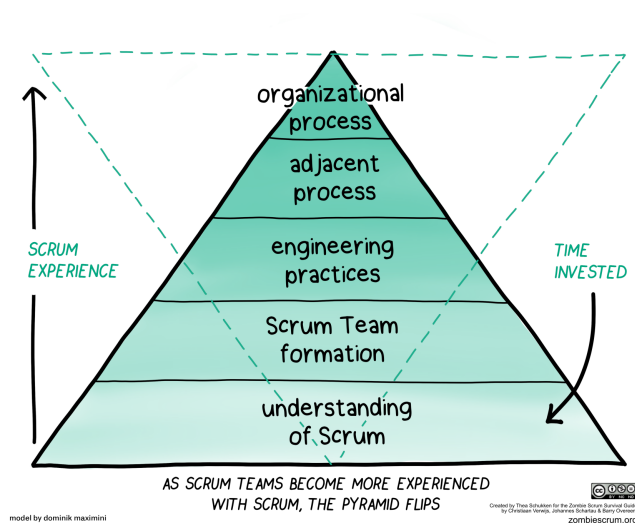
Imagine a Scrum team is dealing with two members that can't stand each other. Instead of talking about the problem themselves, it is delegated to the Scrum Master to resolve. The actual impediment here is the inability of the team to deal with their own conflicts. Perhaps there is no psychological safety within the Scrum team to talk about it. Or people don't know how to bring up conflicts or lack the courage to do so.

"The actual impediment here is the inability of the team to deal with their own conflicts."

By solving only the problem, the Scrum Master does not help the Scrum team to improve their ability to solve similar problems on their own. Instead, the Scrum Master could facilitate a session where frustrations are aired and where the team mediates solutions (instead of being handed one). The Scrum Master can model the kind of behavior needed for conflict resolution, like asking open-ended questions, showing empathy and finding common ground, and invite members of the team to do the same.

Example #3: Engineering Practices

Suppose the Developers run into problems with their infrastructure. Not being able to deploy applications on their own, they depend on an external team. On the day before the Sprint Review, the Developers are having problems with deployment. An impediment is raised during the Daily Scrum, and the Scrum Master takes it upon himself to get this sorted out.



The problem that is raised is just a symptom of a deeper impediment; the inability of the Developers to do their own deployments or at least solve problems related to deployment. By solving only the problem at hand, the Scrum Master does not help the Developers to improve their ability to solve similar problems on their own. Instead, the Scrum Master can address the actual impediment by helping the team find ways to resolve deployment problems on their own.

"By solving only the problem at hand, the Scrum Master does not help the Developers to improve their ability to solve similar problems on their own."

One solution might be to add the skills of the people to the Scrum team that are needed to do this. Another solution might be for the team to set up and manage their own infrastructure (DevOps). A more low-tech solution might be to create communication channels between the Developers and the people capable of resolving problems in deployments (e.g. liaisons). Whatever the solution, it should emerge from the Scrum team with help from the Scrum Master.

Example #4: Adjacent Processes

Imagine the following scenario. The company you work for is scaling up its effort to deliver an upcoming product that processes banking transactions. Plans are to scale from three to ten Scrum teams, each working on a separate component of the same product. You've been asked to support this process and make sure that it works.

One of the first things you do is host a workshop to develop a Definition of Done with the teams. After going back and forth on this for a while, the teams settle on an approach where each team has their own Definition of Done. This gives each team the greatest flexibility and allows them to get their work done without having to depend on the other teams. Another reason why they think this works well is because each team adheres to different quality standards. Having a shared Definition of Done would be impractical and cause delays.

After a couple of weeks, the teams discover that the work they deliver each Sprint can't be integrated. As a result, nothing has been released yet to the stakeholders and they start to get worried and anxious. The Scrum teams expect you to help resolve this impediment because it clearly prevents them to achieve the Product- and Sprint Goal.

Example #5: Organizational Process

The head of your organization wants to introduce Scrum. Currently, work is organized mostly into functional departments. So there is a department for testing, one for coding and one for architecture and analysis. It has been impressed on management to create cross-functional teams where various skill-sets and specialties are mixed.

As a coach and experienced Scrum Master, the company asks for your help with team formation. The heads of the various departments have already spent a couple of days together to create potential teams. In the process, they've also identified some employees that they are willing to let go of.

Their worry is that these employees will resist the change. The department heads have also worked hard to take into interpersonal relationships, skills, personalities, and personal ambitions. But they're not happy with the result and are looking for your recommendations. They hope you can offer some quick tips, as time is essential and the Scrum teams need to start in a couple of days.

In your experience, the more a Scrum team is involved in its own formation, the easier self-organization will emerge. So right now, you consider the organization's approach to the team forming an impediment in itself.

Resources

- Research: [How Do Scrum Masters Deal With Problems Outside Of Their Team's Control?](#). Together with [Age of Product](#), we asked Scrum Masters how they overcame impediments (including dependencies).
- Book: [The Scrum Culture](#). The original book behind the Impediment Pyramid.



Step 1: Opening

Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then explain the purpose, introduce the stakeholders, and start with the first structure. Superfast!

We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves, or to wait for people to drop in.



Step 2: Select The Most Impactful Impediment With 1-2-4-ALL



After you started the workshop, begin by selecting the most impactful impediment that prevents this organization (or Scrum team, or Scrum teams) from working empirically. We recommend that you pick one that impacts all Scrum teams present. So, most likely you'll end up with impediments related to engineering practices, adjacent processes, or organizational processes. The Liberating Structure [1-2-4-ALL](#) is a great way to quickly involve & engage all participants in sharing ideas.

Invitation



"What is the toughest, challenging, or most impactful impediment that prevents us from building what stakeholders need and/or to ship faster?"

Steps

1. **1 min** Ask everyone to first individually write down what is making it hard for them to build what stakeholders need and/or ship fast(er). How is this blocking them from achieving Sprint Goals? What skills are missing? Where is procedure getting in the way? Which people do they need, but don't have access to?
2. **4 min** Invite people to form pairs, or invite them into breakouts for pairs if you're doing this virtually. In their pairs, invite everyone to build on their individual ideas.
3. **6 min** Invite pairs to find another pair. If you do this virtually, merge breakout rooms. In their groups, ask everyone to share their ideas and to select and refine one impediment that they feel is the most impactful and most relevant to the people present.
4. **14 min** Each group pitches their impediment and explains what is so impactful about it. Together, the group selects one impediment to focus on during the workshop. The other impediments are captured in a shared workspace for future sessions or another round of Wise Crowds.

Our Findings

- The impediment you select doesn't necessarily have to impact all Scrum teams. It's also fine to focus on an impediment that only occurs in one team. Use this as an opportunity to gather fresh ideas from other teams and stakeholders.
- 1-2-4-ALL is purposefully quick. Even though people may individually struggle to generate much, the group as a whole will. You can always do a second 1-2-4-ALL if you need to go deeper.
- Facilitate the silent self-reflection firmly, before the paired conversations, and invite everyone to write down their ideas. This allows participants to focus and make ideas tangible and specific.

Resources

- The [original article](#) for "1-2-4-ALL" from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Engage Everyone Simultaneously in Generating Questions, Ideas, and Suggestions with 1-2-4-ALL](#)





Step 3: Tap The Wisdom Of The Whole Group To Find Potential Solutions

In the previous step, the group selected the toughest, challenging, and most impactful impediment that prevents them from building what stakeholders need and/or to ship fast. In this round, the Liberating Structure [Wise Crowds](#) is used to tap into the wisdom of the entire group and overcome this challenge.

Wise Crowds creates a space where people can both get help on a persistent challenge and work with others to develop and practice helping behaviors that help overcome other challenges. Wise Crowds makes it possible to instantly engage a small or large group of people in helping one another.



Steps

1. Prepare by setting up the space so that there is a circle of chairs in the middle. One of the chairs is for the client, the others are for the "primary consulting team". Place small groups of chairs around the inner circle for the "satellite groups". When done virtually, make sure the client and primary consultants are distinct from the other participants. For example, by adding an asterisk in front of their name, and/or only have them turn on their webcams.
2. **2 min** Ask who is willing to act as the "client". If the impediment is shared by all teams, ask someone from the team that's impacted the most to become the client. This person presents the impediment and the challenge based on what came out of the 1-2-4-ALL.
3. **2 min** Ask for 3–5 volunteers who would like to become the primary consultants. Ideally, these are people that bring fresh ideas and insights to resolve the impediment. Invite them to take the seats in the middle while everyone else forms small groups of 3–4 people and takes position around the inner circle.
4. **5 min** Ask the client to present his/her challenge and request for help. The client shares the challenge, provides context, and makes a request for help. Everyone else listens with full attention. In virtual sessions, we often ask the satellite groups to turn off their webcams and mute their microphones so that only the client and the primary consultants are visible.
5. **2 min** The primary consulting team asks clarifying questions to the client in a way that allows everyone to hear the questions and the answers (e.g. with a microphone). Although many participants were involved in the selection of the challenge, this is an opportunity to better understand the challenge, its causes, and consequences.
6. **2 min** The client turns off the webcam and audio and gets ready to take notes. The satellite teams turn off their webcams as well, this makes clear who the primary consultants are. During an in-person workshop, the client (literally) turns his or her back to the primary consultants by turning their chair around. Although some clients "remedy" the social awkwardness of this step by turning only slightly away, or simply closing their eyes, even the smallest facial expression from the client will influence the ideas that are generated by consultants. So make sure that clients fully turn their back to the consultants.
7. **8 min** The primary consultants consider the challenge and share ideas, ask each other additional questions, and offer suggestions they have for the client. They do so with each other, not with the client. The client does not respond in any way, shape, or form and takes notes instead. The satellite teams listen and take notes as well.
8. **12 min** The satellite teams move into breakout rooms. Every satellite consulting team separately builds on the work of the primary consulting team and generates its own recommendations for the client. Meanwhile, the client turns back to the primary consulting team to discuss what was useful.
9. **10 min** If you have only a handful of satellite groups, or sufficient time, ask each group to share one critique and one

recommendation they haven't heard before. Or to pass if they have already been mentioned. If you have a large number of groups, you can collect the recommendations on index cards or a shared workspace (e.g. Mural).

10. **5 min** The client provides feedback to the consultants, emphasizing what was useful and what he or she takes from the process.
11. Repeat "Wise Crowds" with other clients (other Scrum teams) for different impediments. Or do another round for the same client to go deeper.

Our Findings

- Invite participants not to shy away from presenting complex challenges without easy answers.
- If more people are facing a challenge, you can give them the opportunity to become a client as well.
- Wise Crowds helps groups build the behavioral repertoire to listen, understand, critique, and expand on ideas. It also increases the flow of ideas by exposing people to new ideas and perspectives they may not have considered themselves.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- The [article](#) we wrote about Wise Crowds



Step 4: Define Personal Next Steps

We always close by asking people to write down a personal next step. This way, everyone can contribute to the solution in whatever way is possible for them. Many small steps together easily accumulate to large change.

Invitation

"What is your personal 15% Solution to contribute to the improvements and potential solutions we identified? What is something you can do that you do without permission from other or resources you don't have access to?"

Steps

1. **3 min** Ask everyone to silently generate a list of personal 15% Solutions.
2. **5 min** Form pairs and invite each pair into their own breakouts. In the breakouts, people take turns to share their 15% Solutions. We always encourage listeners to help their partner find a way to guarantee that they will actually do those things (e.g. make it smaller, simpler).

Our Findings

- It is tempting for people to complicate their 15% Solutions, which makes it unlikely they'll actually do them. You can encourage people by asking them "What is the thing you're going to do to work on that [original idea]?"
- You can make individual 15% Solutions transparent on your virtual whiteboard. But make sure that this is optional.

Resources

- The original article on [15% Solutions](#) on the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: Trigger BIG change by starting small with ["15% Solutions"](#)

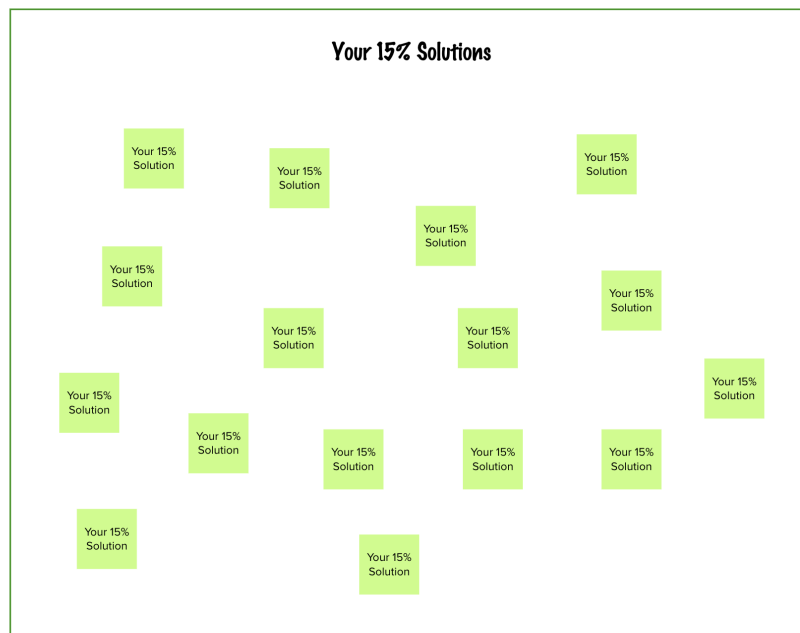
Step 1

Position yourself in the scenario you recognize the most and write down a personal next step.

What is an improvement that you can make, without needing approval from someone else or resources you don't have access to?

Step 2

Pair up and share your 15% Solution while giving and getting help to refine your next step



Step 5: Closing

If you have the time, do a quick debrief with the group. A simple Liberating Structure for this is [Impromptu Networking](#) ("What did you observe, think or feel while participating in this gathering?"). Draw out some salient patterns from the whole group, but keep it short.

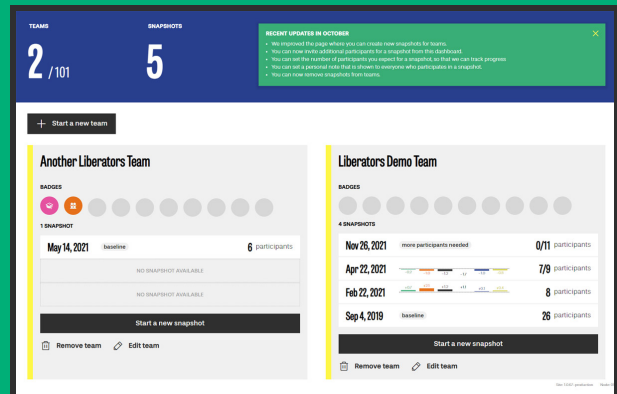
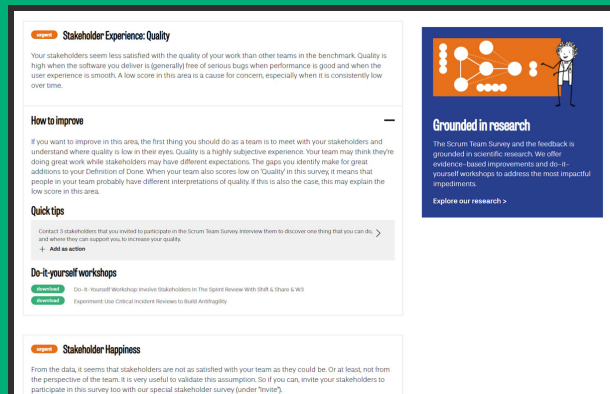
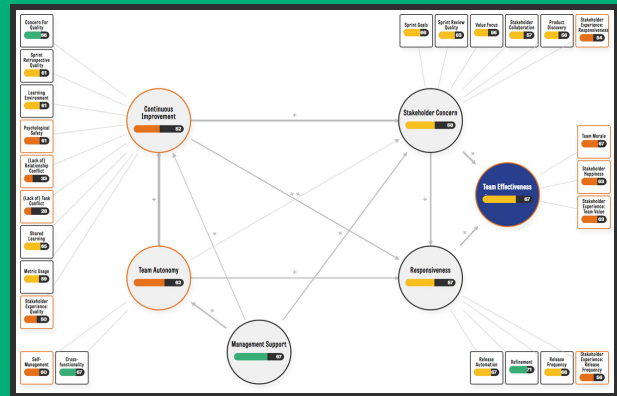
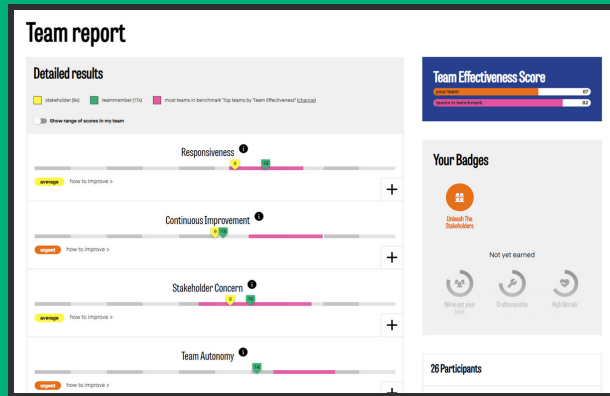
If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

Let's learn and grow, together!



Make Your Scrum Team More Effective

Want to make your Scrum team more effective? We created the Scrum Team Survey to help. Invite members and stakeholders to a detailed questionnaire and diagnose the results together. You receive tons of actionable feedback based on your results, including dozens of quick tips and useful do-it-yourself workshops. You can use the Scrum Team Survey for free with your team. No account or e-mail address is required. You can also subscribe for more advanced features.



	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Analyze the range of scores in your team		✓
Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Team Trends		✓
Support our academic research to help more teams		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 10

<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

info@scrumteamsurvey.org

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